managed to show that horror sells, by writing *Shaitaan* (2024), a film about a family dealing with their daughter falling prey to black magic—and the last Hindi horror flick to cross Rs 100 crore in cinemas. While Khan agrees that *Obsession*'s success will see a surge in interest for horror scripts, he is convinced producers won't "bet on the next big thing or new concept, but will want *Obsession* again". Writer Mrunmayee Lagoo Waikul adds that the genre's poor suitability for family viewing is another reason studios are averse to loosening the pursestrings. "It is a tough territory to crack for mass-viewing," she says.

At the same time, according to producer Anand Pandit, *Obsession* has proved that horror is evolving. "It leans towards psychological storytelling; it's no longer about jump scares or visual effects," he says. Pandit's latest film, *Haunted 3D: Echoes of the Past*, surprised many by surpassing the first-week collections of Imtiaz Ali's *Main Vaapas Aaunga* and the Kangana Ranaut-starrer *Bharat Bhagya Vidhaata*. Directed by Vikram Bhatt (of *Raaz* fame), the film feeds off Bhatt's tried-and-tested formula of sexy damsels distressed or possessed by spirits. Pandit admits that horror lags behind comedies, action and romance because "finding original stories rooted in relatable fears, strong characters and fresh cultural settings" is a tall ask.

A GROWING AUDIENCE

But times are a-changing. There's one target group that's very invested in the genre: the young audience. Sanjeev Bijli, executive director of PVR Inox Ltd, observes that *Obsession*'s success can largely be attributed to this demographic. "They have evolved taste," he says. "For them, old wine in a new bottle isn't working. They want new concepts and unique stories." Last year, young audiences turned up in huge numbers to see two eventual Oscar winners: Ryan Coogler's *Sinners*, a jazz-and-blues-centric vampire flick, and Zach Cregger's *Weapons*, about a town plagued with child disappearances. In the post-pandemic mediascape, PVR Pictures considers acquiring and distributing indie Hollywood horror titles a "safe bet". They recently released *Hokum* (2026), a film about a traumatised writer staying in a haunted hotel.



"THERE'S UNLIMITED SCOPE TO PLAY WITH THE GENRE BUT THERE'S NOT MUCH EXPERIMENTING HAPPENING HERE. WE DON'T TRUST OUR AUDIENCE. MOST FILMS ARE HORROR COMEDIES"

SOHUM SHAH
Actor and producer,
Tumbbad



"THERE IS A CERTAIN JOY IN WATCHING HORROR IN THE CINEMA. IT'S NO FUN WATCHING IT ALONE. YOU FEED OFF EACH OTHER'S REACTIONS, ELEVATING THE EXPERIENCE"

SANJEEV KUMAR BIJLI
Executive Director,
PVR Inox Ltd

"There is a certain joy in watching horror in a cinema. It is a contagious experience where you feed off each other's reactions and fears," he says. Even a niche psychological horror like *Backrooms* (2026), about a series of interconnected mazes in the basement of a furniture store, directed by a rookie 20-year-old in Kane Parsons, found its audience in India, collecting about Rs 9 crore. Bijli hopes that Bollywood takes a leaf out of Hollywood's playbook and backs younger, fresh voices to make horror films, if on modest budgets. Singh is optimistic, too. "I have lost count on how many producers have knocked on my door asking for a horror. I think horror is the next *Dhurandhar*," she says.

Shah, too, is betting big on young audiences to give his sequel to *Tumbbad* the same adulation they did when the original re-released in cinemas in 2024 and collected Rs 30 crore-plus, more than it did in its original run. An atmospheric horror spectacle rooted in Indian folklore, about a family worshipping a forbidden god and featuring top-notch craft from cinematography to background score, the original rightfully enjoys a cult status.

For Shah, the Hindi film industry has still not capitalised on the "unlimited scope" of the genre. He isn't giving up, though, and has bought the rights of three Ramsay cult classics: *Veerana*, *Purani Haweli* and *Purana Mandir*. The hope is to revisit them for a new generation with a different style. Maybe if stars cannot put bums on seats, monsters like Saamri can do the needful. ■